



West Africa

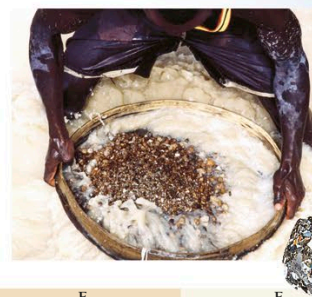
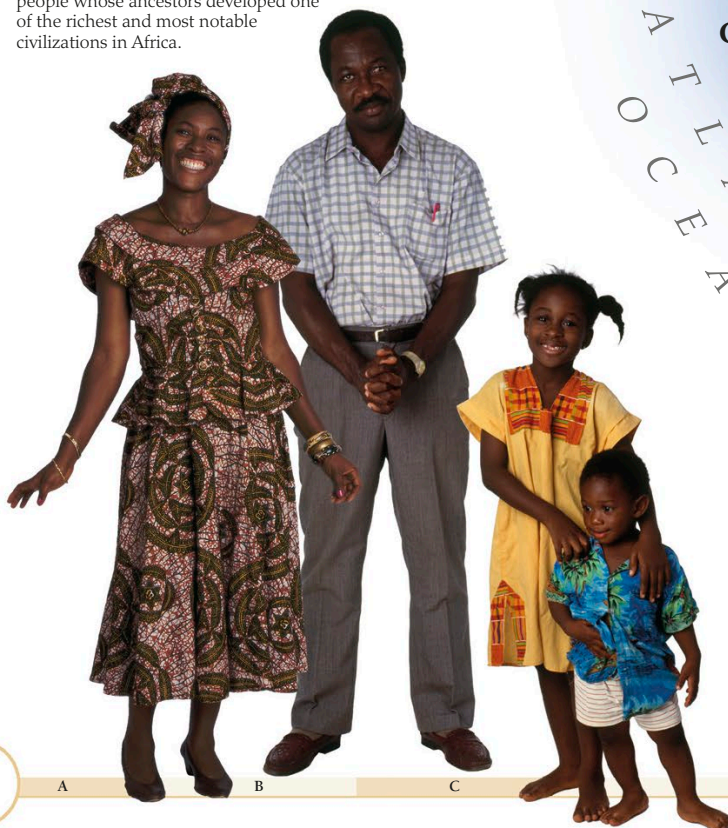
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DRAMATICALLY DIFFERENT CLIMATES and landscapes influence life in west Africa. In the hot, dry north, it is difficult to grow crops. Only oases in the Sahara and seasonal rainfall in the Sahel make growing crops possible. To the south, the climate is warm and wet, and crops such as cocoa and coffee are grown on large plantations. This region also has many valuable minerals. Despite these rich resources, most countries are poor. Since independence from colonial powers, there has been much political unrest, often sparked by poverty and tribal rivalries in the region. West Africa is also divided by religion, with Islam dominant in the north and Christianity in the south.



GAMBIA
In recent years, tourism has become increasingly important to the economy of Gambia. Visitors come to see wildlife along the Gambia River and to visit the Atlantic coast beaches. These safari tourists are admiring a giant termite mound.

PEOPLE OF GHANA
Family ties and a sense of community are important to the people of Ghana, and ceremonies throughout each year mark the events of childbirth, puberty, marriage, and death. About half of Ghanaians are Ashanti people whose ancestors developed one of the richest and most notable civilizations in Africa.



DIAMONDS AND GOLD
West Africa has many valuable minerals, including diamonds, uranium, copper, and gold. In Sierra Leone, where diamonds (left) provide crucial income, the mines were a focus of fighting in the civil war between rebel groups and the government.